

"James & Hephaestus"
and help, 1st hr. - 26 min

LECTURE 5 CELTIC RELIGION

When speaking of 'Celtic religion', many people are referring to the insular Celtic mythology of which we have written records, tho they are "Christianized"

However, religion is not merely mythology, tho the sacred traditions of the latter often account for beliefs relating to ritual practices and festivals.

There is a fine line between what is mythology and what is religion, by which we mean the cults of deities, and the rites and beliefs associated with them.

Since the Celts did not leave us written records of their beliefs in a systematic form, some have expressed the belief that it is impossible to summon the pre-Christian Celtic religion from the grave and have simply left it up to those who have "romanticized" their beliefs during the 17th, 18th and 19th centuries.

These romantics claim all manner of weird rituals for the ancient Celts. However, when we examine the evidence, there is much we know about Celtic religion.

WHAT WE KNOW:

Like almost all the religions of the ancient world, Celtic religion was polytheistic. There are over 400 names of Celtic deities, male and female, recorded but the vast majority would appear to be local deities, tribal gods and goddesses.

However, that leaves some hundred or so who are to be found thruout the Celtic world; indeed, many of the deities are clearly the major deities of the Celts.

As a Roman, Caesar saw the Celtic religion as something exotic, alien and barbaric. However the themes of the common Indo-European inheritance are still there to be observed, and the pantheon of Celtic deities is not far removed from the pantheon

of Latin, Greek or even Hindu deities.

The Celtic deities were as fallible, unpredictable and were subject to all the human vices as were the deities of Mount Olympus in Greek mythology.

The problem is that the Greek and Roman observers have added to our confusion by attempting to equate the Celtic deities with their own and also by comments which seem at odds with the evidence.

MAJOR DEITIES

The Celts seem to have pictured, at least some of their deities, in human form tho there is conflict over whether they did or did not. Caesar says that the Celts believed that the deities were their ancestors and not their creators, so surely, they had human form.

Indeed, we have an image of CERNUNNOS, clearly in human form with horns coming out of his head, from the 4th cent. BC rock scratching.

CERNUNNOS was certainly a major god. The name seems to indicate "the horned one" and he is often depicted with the symbol of stag's antlers--which remained a royal symbol among the Irish Kings.

It has been argued that Cernunnos of the Continental and British Celts is the DAGDA (the good God) of Irish mythology.

Beneath the cathedral of Notre Dame in Paris in 1711, a monument was found dating to around 14 - 37 AD. He is bearded, with stag's antlers from which hang hero's torcs. It appears that he was sitting in the Lotus position, tho the lower part has been lost.

There are over 300 figures of gods found in the Celtic world adopting this classic meditation position so closely associated in the modern mind with the Buddhist or Hindu religions.

Sometimes Cernunnos is found with a female consort at times, also with antlers. Sometimes he has a ram horned snake, and in

one relief he is pictured as feeding the snake.

He appears so often that it is fair to say that Cernunnos is a major god in the Celtic pantheon. He has many of the attributes of Shiva of the Hindu pantheon, -- Lord of animals and the male generative force,--among other things.

As we saw in the first lecture, the Celts believed that their origins lay with the mother goddess, DANU meaning 'divine waters' from 'heaven'.

She fell from heaven and her waters created the danuvius (Danube), having watered the sacred oak tree BÍĚ. From this sprang the pantheon of the gods who are known as the TUATHA DE DANAAN (the children of Danu) in Irish and the Children of Don in Welsh myths.

TRIUNE DEITIES

Most of the major Celtic deities were venerated in the form of triune gods and goddesses--that is, they had three aspects called by three names, and many representations of them are given three faces or three heads.

The sacredness of the number 3 is a highly important and a very common feature of the Indo-European tradition. This triune or triple form of deity was not confined to the Celts but permeates the Indo-European culture. In Hindu belief this trinity consisted of Brahma the Creator, Vishnu the Preserver, and Shiva the destroyer.

Ancient Greeks used three as a symbol of deity and also had their triune aspect in Zeus (heaven), Poseidon (sea), and Pluto/hades (underworld).

There are of course three Fates, three Furies, three Graces, three Harpies and the Sibylline books are numbered as three times three as are the Muses.

Ireland was represented by a female triune goddess--Eire, Danba and Fotla-- and there were three craft gods, Goibhniu,
Goibhniu

Lúchtá and Crédhné

The Morrighu, ^{Mor rí ghá} triple goddess of death and battles, appeared as Macha, ^{Má cā} Bodb, ^{Báb} and Nemain, ^{Né man} embodying all that is perverse and horrible among the supernatural powers. The Dagda himself was worshipped in triune form.

PHILOSOPHICALLY this can go even deeper for the Celts saw human beings as body, soul and spirit; The world was divided into earth, sea and air, the divisions of nature were animal, vegetable, and mineral and the cardinal colors were red, yellow and blue.

It was a Celt from Gaul, Hilary, bishop of Poitiers (315-367 AD) whose great work De Trinitate defined the concept of the Holy Trinity for the first time., a view that is now part of orthodox Christian belief.

MORE DEITIES:

LUGUS, found throughout the continent in both inscriptions and in place names of towns such as Lyons, Leon, Loudan, in France and Leiden (in Holland), etc. also appears on the British Isles in place names.

His festival on August 1 marked the beginning of the harvest season and the name of this festival, ^{Lúg ná sá} Lughnasad, survives as a name for the month of August in Modern Irish as ^{Lu ná sa} Lunasa and in Scottish Gaelic as Lúnasá.

Lugh and his Welsh equivalent Lleu appear in the insular Celtic myths. He is portrayed as a warrior god of shining light. He is master of all crafts and skills.

^{Nú á da} Nuada, ruler of the gods in Ireland, surrenders his rule to Lugh who is also called Lugh Lamhfhada (of the Long Hand/arm). or the skillful hand. ^{Lám fá da}

In the Hindu pantheon the god ^{SÁVĪTĀR} is called ^{pr thā pā nē} prthupani (of the large hand) and in the Rig veda (c. 1200 BC) both Lugus and Savitar are claimed as solar deities. "the God with the great hand stretches up his arms so that all obey."

The god of the large hand is an Indo-European concept and known from Ireland and Sweden to the Punjab of India.

^{Og mee & s}
OGMIOS is the god of eloquence, literacy and learning. He is found on the continent and in Britain as Ogmia and in Ireland as Ogma.

Ogma in Ireland is a son of the Dagda and he is credited with the invention of the Ogam script, which is named after him.

The Greeks identified him with Hercules and this is confirmed in the insular mythological sources, where his parentage and adventures are in many ways comparable with those of Heracles, son of Zeus, father of the Greek gods. Zeus, of course, is cognate with Dyaus in Sanskrit and the Dagda in Irish.

BRÍGÁNDŪ or BRÍGÍT whose name means "exalted one" today has a feast day of a saint who bears her name. It is suggested that she was another personification of Danu.

She is identified as the Celtic equivalent of Minerva on a relief from southern Scotland, now in Edinburgh, which portrays her with Minerva's accoutrements.

Brigantia was worshipped in Britain, primarily in the north. Her name also appears in names of rivers.

In Ireland, as Brigit, she appears in the myths as the daughter of the Dagda with two sisters, also called Brigit. She is associated with the art of healing and the craft of the smithy and was a patroness of poetry. Overall, she was the goddess of fertility.

The Christian saint who bears her name, Brigit (c.455AD - 525 AD), not only took over the feast day of the goddess, the traditional commencement of spring, or Imbolc in old Irish (February 1) but also encompassed the veneration of fertility and light.

St Brigit's cross, when examined, is a solar wheel, a symbol of good fortune which appears throughout Indo-European culture and in Hindu culture as the swastika, a symbol, of course, perverted

by the Nazis. *svāstīkā*

In Sanskrit, Svastika derived from su = Good and asti, being.

the problem with Celtic deities is that it is impossible to identify a rigid structure of the gods. *shaw "Fames & heprachans"*
***** *Break 27 min*

HEAD TAKING AND PRESERVATION

The Romans feigned shock and horror at the Celtic practice of taking and preserving the heads of people that they admired, whether they were friend or foe.

Most of the classical sources refer to the Celts taking the heads of their enemies after they had fallen in battle and it is noted as early as 295 BC, after the Senones tribe smashed a Roman legion at clusium, that: *जे नो नः*

They cut off the heads of enemies slain in battle and attach them to the necks of their horses. The bloodstained spoils they hand over to their attendants and carry off the booty, while striking up a paean and singing a song of victory; and they nail up these first fruits upon their houses. . . They enbalm in cedar oil the heads of the most distinguished enemies, and preserve them carefully in a chest and display them with pride to strangers, saying that for this head one of their ancestors, or his father, or the man himself, refused the offer of a large sum of money. They say that some of them boast that they refused the weight of the head in gold.

But the Celts believed that the soul reposed in the head. Strabo, among others says that the Celts believed that the Human soul was indestructable. Thus, the head was venerated as the source and power of the human spirit.

It was the mark of great respect to take the head of one they admired, to enbalm it in cedar oil and offer it up in a temple or keep it as a prized possession.

Dr. James argues however that: "by keeping the head of an enemy, they may have thought that the spirit was also controlled."

We are told by Livy that the Boii, having killed the Roman consul in 216 BC, took his head to their temple. The Celts also

put heads into sacred rivers as votive offerings.

It is quite wrong to interpret this as evidence that the Celts were 'head hunters'. They did not go out looking for heads. Decapitation only took place after the victims were slain in battle or died, and then only if they were deemed worthy of respect.

Archaeological evidence from various sources supports the information on temple offerings. A number of skulls have been found in Celtic shrines. At Entremont, capital of the Saluvii, fragments of a statue have been recovered and a reconstruction shows a figure seated in the Lotus position bearing on its lap six severed heads. The figure wears a conical war helmet and a torc around his neck.

Entremont was destroyed by the Romans in 124 BC. Excavations of the shrine have shown that it was on the highest part of the hill and approached by a pathway lined with statues of heroes and heroines. Within this shrine stood a tall pillar carved with 12 heads. Entremont is remarkable for a large array of severed head sculpture.

the mythological traditions of Ireland and Wales are full of references to the importance of the head. Heads were endowed with the ability to live on once separated from the body, confirming the idea of the soul reposing there.

In the poem *Mabinogion*, Bran ^{Bēn digfran} Bēn digfran is mortally wounded by a poison. He orders his men to cut off his head before the poison reaches it, and to take the head back to Britain. on the journey, the head talks, jokes and gives advice to them.

Heads often talk once stricken from the body. The famous decapitation game in *Sir Gawain and the Green Knight* has its origin in Celtic myth and appears in one of the Red Branch tales with Cuchulainn in the role later assumed by Gawain.

CUCHULAINN takes the heads of his enemies w/o compunction

and, like the Celts mentioned by Diodorus Siculus, he hands them from his chariot, " . . . terribly, he comes. He has in the chariot the bloody heads of his enemies."

CHRISTIANITY AND HEADTAKING

The reverence for the head was not displaced by Christianity for many centuries. The doors of several churches in Ireland display a preoccupation with heads.

One professor has remarked that it is often impossible to distinguish pre-Christian and Christian Celtic head carvings.

The gargoyles, corbels and other decorative forms on churches, particularly down to the 11th and 12th centuries AD, owed much to the Celtic belief that the soul dwelt in the head. (play song about Oran's head, Columba's brother from "stone of destiny".)

TO COMPLETE THIS SECTION I WANT TO PLAY A SONG BY STEVE MCDONADD ABOUT ORAN, THE BROTHER OF ST. COLUMBA. THE STORY IS A DARK ONE. THE BROTHER TRAVELED FROM IRELAND WITH COLUMBA AND A DOZEN OR SO OTHER DISCIPLES ON THEIR GREAT MISSIONARY PILGRIMAGE. THEY BUILT A CHAPEL AT IONA, WHICH THEY DEDICATED TO ORAN BECAUSE OF A STRANGE, SCARY HAPPENING.

COLUMBA WANTED TO CONSECRATE THE LAND WITH A BURIAL AND IT WAS DEEMED NECESSARY FOR SOMEONE TO BE BURIED ALIVE. ORAN VOLUNTEERED, AND AFTER A LENGTHY AGREEMENT WITH HIS BROTHER OVER THE NATURE OF HEAVEN AND HELL, HE DESCENDED INTO A PIT WHICH WAS THEN FILLED WITH DIRT.

AFTER 90 DAYS THE PIT WAS OPENED AND WHEN THEY DISCOVERED ORAN'S HEAD IT SPOKE TO THEM, SAYING: " HEAVEN IS NOT WHAT IT IS SAID TO BE, HELL IS NOT WHAT IT IS SAID TO BE, THE SAVED ARE NOT FOREVER HAPPY, THE DAMNED ARE NOT FOREVER LOST."

UPON HEARING THIS, COLUMBA WAS CONVINCED A DEMON POSSESSED HIS BROTHER'S BODY AND QUICKLY HAD THE CORPSE BURIED AGAIN.

THE GRAVEYARD BECAME SCOTLAND'S ROYAL CEMETERY WITH SIXTY KINGS, SCOTTISH, IRISH AND NORSE BURIED THERE, INCLUDING MACBETH. (PLAY "ORAN", #4 ON STONE OF DESTINY

CELTS, THE AFTERLIFE AND OTHERWORLD

The Celts believed in an afterlife. The Gaulish teaching was that the soul was immortal. Some Romans believed that the philosophy of Pythagoras that of the souls immortality and belief in reincarnation, was gotten from the Greeks or others argued that the Greeks got it from the Celts.

Pythagoras never wrote anything down, and neither did the Celts, of a religious nature. It is from later writers we know what he taught.

However, in other Indo-European cultures, notably in India, it was believed that due to its karma a soul transmigrated from one life to another in a never ending cycle which could only be broken by achieving Mokse/nirvana, a state of supreme bliss which, once achieved, liberated the soul from the repeating cycle of death and rebirth.

THE OTHERWORLD

The CELTIC idea of immortality was that death was but a changing of place and that life went on with all its forms and goods in another world, a world of the dead, or the fabulous "otherworld".

When people died in that world, however, their souls were reborn in this. Thus a constant exchange of souls took place between the two worlds; death in this world took a soul to the Otherworld, death in that world brought a soul to this one.

One Roman writer noted in about 225 that the Celts celebrated birth with mourning for the death in the Otherworld, and regarded death with joy for birth in the Otherworld.

So firm was the Celtic belief in the Otherworld, according to one early first century writer, that "They lent sums of money to each other which are repayable in the next world, so firmly are they convinced that the souls of men are immortal."

As we have seen, rich grave goods, personal belongings,

weapons, food and drink were buried with the dead to give them a good start in the Otherworld.

Most likely the Celts did not borrow their philosophy from the Greeks, nor the other way around. The evolution of the doctrine of immortality of the soul was a parallel and differing development in several Indo-European cultures, and might originate from an earlier common belief. This is called the *phenomenological* view

The term OTHERWORLD is used here for this world because it has become so popular. The Insular Celts themselves had numerous names for the Otherworld--all euphemisms. for example, there are over half a dozen names for the sun and the moon, with prohibitions as to when those words could be used.

To take Irish Mythology alone some synonyms for the Otherworld are: Tir na nog (land of youth this was the name of a TV show also), Tir Tairnigiri (land of promise), Magh Mell (Plain of Happiness), Dun Scāith (fortress of shadows), and Hy-Breasail (Breasal's island). There are others, but you get the idea.

Insular Celtic literature is filled with stories of voyages or journeys to the Otherworld. The Otherworld, for the brave traveller who undertook the journey, could be reached by various means, thru a cave, in a lake, but most popularly by voyaging across the great sea to the south west or west.

Even in modern English we have a survival of this --When someone was killed in wartime he was referred to as having "gone west". One Irish name, Hy-Breasail, was so accepted in people's minds as a real land to the west that it was marked on medieval maps. When the Portuguese explorer Cabral reached South America, he thought he had discovered Hy-Breasail and thus named the country Brazil.

The gathering place of the souls of the dead was always

regarded as a small island to the south-west of Ireland and a similar belief was held in Wales. The souls were then transported by the god of the dead to the Otherworld.

The actual location of the Otherworld, whether in this world or a spirit world not of this Earth, has caused some confusion. Some have implied it is an area of this earth that is not known to us.

Furthermore, there are many different concepts of what the otherworld was like, ranging from dark and brooding places to happy, rural paradises.

^{sow en} SAMHAIN/HALLOWEEN

There was one day of the year when the otherworld could become visible to this world: on the feast of Samhain, the eve of 31 October to 1 November.

This was a time when the supernatural boundry between the two worlds was broken down and people, the dead and living, could move freely between the two lands.

It was a time when those who had been wronged by the living could return and haunt them.

Christianity, unable to suppress the belief, adopted it. October 31 became All hallows Eve or Hallowe'en and All Saints Day was Nov. 1.

In Irish myth there are two "gatekeepers", the deities who escorted souls to the Otherworld: ^{rec} Tech Duinn ^{Don} (house of Donn) was the name given to the assembly place of the dead off the southwest of Ireland.

ADMINISTRATION

Most classical writers say the Druids were the administrators of the religion because they "profess to know the will of the Gods."

Caesar says: "The Druids officiate at the worlship of the gods, regulate public and private sacrifices, and give rulings on all

religious questions."

Clearly this is only a small part of what a Druid did. We will discuss them soon. Suffice it to say, as already stated, that the Druids were the intellectual class and incorporated the priesthood within their ranks.

This is why the Greeks and the Romans are not consistent in using the word Druid for a priest and why druids are not referred to in many parts of the celtic world while the intellectual professions are mentioned.

MORAL CODE:

From the various insular sources, comparing them to classical writer's comments, we may argue that the Celtic priesthood taught that the ideal was for people to live in harmony with nature and themselves, accepting that pain and death were not evils but essential parts of the divine plan, and that the only evil was moral weakness.

Scholars today see that the notion of Truth as the highest principle and sustaining power of creation pervaded all early Irish literature.

The old Irish word for "truth" is the basis for the linguistic concepts of holiness, righteousness, faithfulness, as well as for religion and for justice. Even today when a person dies one says: "He/she is in the place of Truth now."

this basic philosophy of pre-Christian Celtic religion has many parallels with eastern Indo-European concepts. There is an exact parallel with Zoroastrian belief.

In the Hindu Vedas Truth is a land in the highest state of paradise and the source of the sacred Ganges. The Vedas say, "By means of Truth the earth endures."

The Celtic Religion was based on a moral system which distinguished right from wrong. Moral salvation was the responsibility of the individual.

 PELAGIUS (354-420 AD) A Celtic Christian, was accused of reviving pre-christian philosophies, specifically the 'Natural

Philosophy of the Druids'; He argued that men and women could take the initial and fundamental steps towards their salvation, using their own efforts and not accepting things as preordained.

AUGUSTINE OF HIPPO, in reaction to Pelagius views, taught that mankind took on Adam's original sin and had no free will in effecting its own salvation. Whether they did good deeds or bad in life, they were already fated, everything was preordained.

Pelagius argued that Augustine's theories imperiled the entire moral law. If men and women were not responsible for their good or evil deeds, there was nothing to restrain them from an indulgence in evil doing on the basis that it was preordained and they were not responsible.

Pelagius arguments were an echo of the more progressive aspect of pre-Christian Celtic philosophy but Augustine prevailed and Pelagius was declared a heretic.

For centuries the celtic christian movement was considered to be imbued with Pelagius' teachings. It was not that the Celts consciously accepted Pelagius' teachings, but the belief that men and women had free will and were responsible for their actions was an essential part of Celtic culture.

Curiously, although for all practical purposes, Christianity finally accepted Pelagius' teachings, Augustine is still regarded as a saint and Pelagius as a heretic.

There were other Celtic philosophers writing tracts which are now all lumped together as 'Pelagian.' They all show a social philosophy which has distinct echos in insular Celtic Law systems.

In 411 AD, at the very time Pelagius was arguing with Augustine, a Celtic Bishop wrote:

Do you think yourself Christian if you oppress the poor? . . . if you enrich yourself by making others poor? If you wring your food from

other's tears? A Christian is a man who. . .never allows a poor man to be oppressed when he is by, . . .whose doors are open to all, whose table every poor man knows, whose food is offered to all.

The hospitality of Celtic kings and chieftains is well documented in mythology and stipulated in law. The rights and duties of a ruler to see that no one, particularly strangers in his land, went hungry, the law forbidding the exploitation of workers, the fines in Irish law for anyone profiting from causing injury -- all these point to the fact that Pelagius and the other Pelagian writers shared a particular cultural background.

HUMAN SACRIFICE AND DIVINATION

We will do more with divination in a later lecture, but for now I want to touch on it from the viewpoint of religion.

The Celts, like most ancient peoples, practiced divination, foretelling the future or will of the gods by the presence of good or bad omens.

the Greeks and Romans claimed that the Celtic priests searched for prophetic signs in the entrails of sacrificial animals and in the flight of birds. AUGURY, or bird flight, was a method particularly used by the Etruscans who, like the Romans and other civilizations, also looked for signs in animal entrails. There was a college of Etruscan augers established in Rome.

Most the historians used one source, ^{Pōs T dōn Yūs} Poseidonius, as their expert on Celtic divination. He claimed that the Druids (or druid priests) divined from the death throes of human victims. Caesar repeated the information.

They described the Celtic priests as plunging a dagger into a victim and watching his death throes. Tacitus, echoing these earlier writers, says "The Druids consult the gods in the palpitating entrails of men."

Indeed, the reputation of the ancient Celts as indulging in human sacrifice relies on several Roman orientated writers, who ^{can} all be traced back to one informant only--Poseidonius.

Those who mention human sacrifice all explain that it was only used in divination or to propitiate the gods. Cicero repeats: "they find it necessary to propitiate the immortal gods and defile their altars and temples with human victims."

Human sacrifice in religious matters was certainly practised in the ancient Indo-European world and we may ask why the Celts should have been singled out for criticism in this way.

First, there is only one source for all these stories, already mentioned and second, the Romans had an agenda of their own in denigrating the Celts and making them seem less than human.

The curious thing is that the Romans practiced human sacrifice themselves. After Hannibal's victory at Cannae in 216 BC, the Romans sacrificed two Celtic and two Greek prisoners by burying them alive in the forum in Rome to propitiate their gods.

Roman writers loved to talk about Celtic savagery, the quality of being fierce, cruel and uncivilized. By Rome's own bloodthirsty standards, any Celtic cruelty seems to have been quite mild. Ritual killings were a way of Roman life and many state prisoners were ceremonially executed to appease the gods of war.

Vercingetorix, already mentioned, who surrendered to save his people in 52 BC was incarcerated for 6 years and then ritually slaughtered to celebrate caesar's triumph.

This form of sacrifice reached its peak in the fourth century AD. Diocletian (284-305 AD) is recorded as having 17,000 men, women and children slaughtered in the arena in one month alone.

By the first century AD most Roman writers, even if begrudgingly, agreed that human sacrifice among the Celts was a thing of the past.

They obviously could not repeat Poseidonius' comments as applying to their own time; a time when tens of thousands were being ritually slaughtered in the Roman arena for the sake of Entertainment.

~~entertainment.~~

To conclude, it is certainly true to say that in the insular Celtic literatures there is no tradition, no shadow of a tradition, of human sacrifice. As this material was written down by Christian clerics, who would have taken any opportunity to denigrate the pagan beliefs of their ancestors, it must be argued that had there been any such practice it would have come under fierce attack.
